

Union home minister Amit Shah, in the company of BJP national president J.P. Nadda, took the call keeping in mind the long-term imperative of consolidation with continuity. Though the decisions had been taken on December 4 itself, just a day after the results came in, the trio waited a week before announcing the names in a staggered manner. A luxury that the Congress could ill afford in Telangana, India's youngest state, where it wrested power from the ruling Bharat Rashtra Samithi with a slender majority. In demonstrating that it will not be left behind, the Grand Old Party made the strapping Anumula Revanth Reddy the chief minister of Telangana. The 54-year-old firebrand had joined the Congress only in 2017.

THE POLITICAL LOGIC

In trying to explain the BJP's choice of chief ministers, a top BJP leader said, "In the BJP, organisation comes first, then the individual. When decisions are taken, they are taken for the larger good of the society and party. The chief ministerial choices reflect this." Victory in the latest round of elections has been a triumph of Modi's charisma among the voters along with the party's strong organisational muscle and election-oriented machinery. "It complements the popularity of the local leaders in the state," says the BJP leader. Confident of its present, the party is looking to fortify its future, in which pursuit it is cultivating a younger leadership and allowing them to evolve.

That new reality was more than evident in the fact that Rajnath Singh, who travelled to Jaipur as the party observer for Sharma's election as the legislature party leader, is among the last links to the fast-fading Atal Bihari Vajpayee era. Ditto with the formidable local satraps—Vasundhara Raje Scindia, 70, who was chief minister twice; Chouhan, 67, in the saddle for four terms; and Raman Singh, 71, a three-term CM—who were nudged to step back and make way for the younger crop of leaders.

Perceptions about ringing in change of this magnitude vary. Some sceptics reckon it is a risk ahead of the parliamentary polls. Most, however, believes fresh faces will bring in more than a whiff of fresh air. Over the past two decades, leaders have become so entrenched that they have stifled the growth of new leadership in these states. It was to check this trend that the Modi-Shah conducted this nuanced experiment in social engineering to indicate that diversity will be the new mantra of the party, a signal that has been transmitted across the Hindi heartland in time for the general election. To make good the handicap that none in the trio of CMs is a frontline leader either of his caste or community nor has commanding oratory skills, the BJP is replicating the Uttar Pradesh model of having two deputy chief ministers. It helps balance caste aspirations and also allows the party to absorb what may seem cataclysmic change at the top.

EVEN WHEN CONGRESS GOT EVERYTHING WRONG ELSEWHERE, IT GOT GENERATIONAL SHIFT RIGHT IN TELANGANA WHERE AN AGGRESSIVE REDDY TOOK THE FIGHT TO THE ENEMY CAMP

Handholding by the party's national leadership both in policymaking and in tackling the fragile financial conditions in all three states will allow seasoned hands to guide the inexperienced leadership. It will also give the new leaders the strength to face challenges and the time to strengthen the party and deliver the benefits of "double-engine sarkar" in their states. And all this without getting rid of the satraps. Raman Singh will be Speaker of the new Vidhan Sabha in Raipur,